Dr. Jane Doe's Office

What to Expect During Your Pulmonary Function Test

What is a Pulmonary Function Test?

A pulmonary function test (PFT) checks how well your lungs work. You will do the test inside of a clear, airtight box or while sitting in a chair. A PFT is an outpatient test that does not require you stay in the hospital.

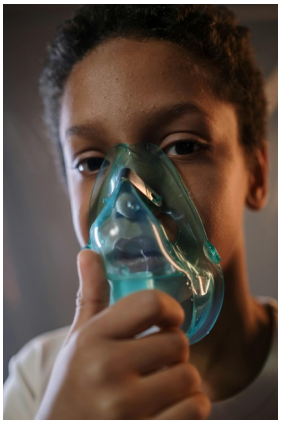
What are the Types of Pulmonary Function Tests?

The most common test is spirometry. This test measures how much air you can breathe in and breathe out and estimates how much air is in your lungs.

Body plethysmography measures how much air is in your lungs at different times while you are breathing in and breathing out. It gives your doctor more information than spirometry.

A gas diffusion study can tell how much oxygen, carbon dioxide, and other gases move from your lungs to your blood.

A cardiopulmonary exercise test measures how well your heart and lungs work during exercise.



When is a Pulmonary Function Test done?

If you have asthma, chronic obstructive pulmonary disease (COPD), pulmonary fibrosis, or trouble breathing, your doctor

may order a PFT. Your doctor can use the test results to diagnose breathing problems or tell you if your breathing is getting worse.

Preparing for a Pulmonary Function Test

You should wear loose and comfortable clothing for your test. Do not do any heavy exercise before your test, like going to the gym or running. Do not use tobacco products or vapes before your test. Depending on the type of PFT your doctor orders, your doctor may tell you to stop taking your breathing medicines until after you finish the test.

You should avoid caffeine and eating a heavy meal before your test.

How is a Pulmonary Function Test done?

A PFT is done in an outpatient clinic, usually at the hospital or in some doctors offices. A specially trained Respiratory Therapist will complete your PFT. The Respiratory Therapist will give you instructions on how to breathe during the test your doctor ordered.

The Respiratory Therapist will also ask for or confirm your height, weight, age, race, and sex. This information is important so that your results are accurate.

Spirometry, body plethysmography, or gas diffusion tests will be completed while you are in a clear, airtight box called a "body box." You will be given soft nose clips that you must wear so that all the air you breathe in and out goes through your mouth. You will also be given a mouthpiece that connects to the testing device.

The Respiratory Therapist will tell you exactly how to breathe at each point during the specific test or tests. You will probably be asked to repeat the same type of breathing three or more times so that your best results can be determined. It is important to follow the Respiratory Therapist's directions. Your doctor may not be able to diagnose breathing problems if you do not breathe correctly during the test.

How Long Does a Pulmonary Function Test Take?

You should plan to spend 15 to 60 minutes depending on the test your doctor has ordered. It may take longer if your doctor wants you to complete more than one test.

What Are the Risks of Pulmonary Function Tests?

PFTs are mostly safe. You may feel dizzy, lightheaded, or cough because you will be breathing deeply. Let the Respiratory Therapist know if you feel dizzy or lightheaded so you can take a break during the test. These symptoms should go away shortly after your test is done.

A serious but very rare side effect of testing is a collapsed lung.

Results and Follow-Up

The Respiratory Therapist will give your results to your doctor so they can compare your results to the expected results of someone with your same demographics (age, sex, height, weight, and race). Your doctor should inform you of your results within a few days of completing the test.

In some cases, your results may not give your doctor enough information. This can happen if you are unable to complete certain parts of the test. Your doctor may ask you to retake the test depending on the results of the other parts of the test.

Need More Information?

Contact your doctor by calling 555-555-1000 or scan the QR code with your phone to schedule a call with the doctor.